

STAGE THREE • JOB APPLICATION & INTERVIEW SKILLS

FIRSTS

Job Application & Interview Skills

SESSION 1

Building the Application

FIRSTS C1-C7

Job Application Tracker

- 15, 30+ applications get unmanageable fast
- Which resume version, sent where, followed up when
- Update it, and actually review it

Application Strategy

- Fewer, well-matched beats many, loosely matched
- Tailored materials genuinely outperform generic ones
- Too narrow starves the pipeline; too broad dilutes effort

Resume Version A/B Test

- Generic advice doesn't fit every field or candidate
- Test real versions against real employers
- Change one variable at a time, or you can't learn anything

Cover Letter Customization

- Fully generic is easy to spot, rarely persuasive
- Full rewrites don't scale at real volume
- Efficient customization: the sustainable middle ground

Job Listing Analysis

- Repeated language signals what actually matters
- Order of requirements is a real signal too
- Not every listed skill is equally required

STAR Answer Prep

- Structure prevents rambling under pressure
- Situation/Task brief, Action/Result gets the real time
- Practiced, not memorized word-for-word

Behavioral Interview Prep

- Shows up in nearly every interview, every industry
- Unpracticed stories freeze under real pressure
- One story forced into every answer is a red flag

SESSION 2

Interview Readiness

FIRSTS C8-C14

Technical Interview Prep

- Time pressure + being watched changes everything
- Simulated conditions, not just solo untimed practice
- Understand the concept, not just the memorized answer

Case/Problem-Solving Prep

- Tests how you think under ambiguity
- A framework is a starting point, not a script
- Narrate your thinking out loud, always

Mock Interview

- Reading about it $\neq$ performing under real pressure
- Pick a partner who doesn't already know your answers
- The honest feedback after matters as much as the practice

Job Offer Negotiation Prep

- Most first offers have real room built in
- Fear of seeming ungrateful costs real money
- Research a realistic range — never negotiate blind

Follow-Up Email After Interview

- Can tip a genuinely close decision
- Reference the actual conversation, not a template
- Send it within a day, not several days later

Test/Assessment Prep

- An early, common screening step
- Practice timed — format and timing vary by company
- Never assume all assessments are the same

Mock Presentation

- Tests organizing and delivering, not just answering
- Don't cram content past the actual time limit
- Practice the follow-up questions too, not just the talk

SESSION 3

Closing the Loop

FIRSTS C15-C20

Interview Mindset Routine

- Nerves can undercut even strong preparation
- A consistent routine gives you something to lean on
- Calming and focus-building, not last-minute cramming

Thank-You Email Habit

- One good email helps; a consistent habit builds reputation
- Send it even after interviews that went poorly
- Professionalism people remember, win or lose

Application Deadline Calendar

- Job search overlaps with classes, work, life
- A spreadsheet you don't check daily doesn't count
- Active reminders, not passive tracking

Career-Focused LinkedIn Application

- Cold applications get filtered before a human sees them
- A warm referral routes around that filter
- Context first — never ask a stranger cold

Job Research Sheet

- Interviewers can tell who actually researched
- Beyond the homepage — real, specific findings
- Specific questions, not ones that fit any company

Offer Comparison Matrix

- Excitement and pressure cloud real decisions
- Structure keeps it grounded in what matters to you
- Don't build it and then ignore it for the biggest number

Stage Three, Complete

One real application decision, made with a clear head.